

Dementia is not a specific disease but is rather is the loss of **cognitive functioning** — **thinking, remembering, and reasoning** — to such an extent that it interferes with a person's daily life and activities. Some people with dementia **cannot control their emotions**, and their **personalities may change**. Dementia ranges in severity from the mildest stage, when it is just beginning to affect a person's functioning, to the most severe stage, when the person must depend completely on others for basic activities of daily living, such as feeding oneself.

Dementia affects millions of people and is more common as people grow older (about one-third of all people age 85 or older may have some form of dementia) but it is **not** a normal part of aging. Many people live into their 90s and beyond without any signs of dementia.

What are the signs and symptoms of dementia?

Signs and symptoms of dementia result when once-healthy neurons (nerve cells) in the brain stop working, lose connections with other brain cells, and die. While everyone loses some neurons as they age, people with dementia experience far greater loss.

The signs and symptoms can vary depending on the type and may include:

- Experiencing memory loss, poor judgment, and confusion
- Difficulty speaking, understanding and expressing thoughts, or reading and writing
- Wandering and getting lost in a familiar neighborhood
- Trouble handling money responsibly and paying bills
- Repeating questions
- Using unusual words to refer to familiar objects
- Taking longer to complete normal daily tasks
- Losing interest in normal daily activities or events

- Hallucinating or experiencing delusions or paranoia
- Acting impulsively
- Not caring about other people's feelings
- Losing balance and problems with movement

What are the different types of dementia?

Various neurodegenerative disorders and factors contribute to the development of dementia through a progressive and irreversible loss of neurons and brain functioning. Currently, there is no cure for any type of dementia.

Types of dementia include:

- **Alzheimer's disease (alt·zai·muhz).** This is the most common cause of dementia, accounting for 60 to 80 percent of cases. It is caused by specific changes in the brain. The trademark symptom is *trouble remembering recent events*, such as a conversation that occurred minutes or hours ago, while difficulty remembering more distant memories occurs later in the disease. Other concerns like difficulty with walking or talking or personality changes also come later. Family history is the most important risk factor. Having a first-degree relative with Alzheimer's disease increases the risk of developing it by 10 to 30 percent.
- **Vascular dementia.** About 10 percent of dementia cases are linked to *strokes* or other issues with *blood flow to the brain*. *Diabetes, high blood pressure and high cholesterol are also risk factors*. Symptoms vary depending on the area and size of the brain impacted. The disease progresses in a step-wise fashion, meaning symptoms will suddenly get worse as the individual gets more strokes or mini-strokes.
- **Lewy body dementia.** In addition to more typical symptoms like *memory loss*, people with this form of dementia may have *movement or balance problems* like *stiffness or trembling*. Many people also experience *changes in alertness* including *daytime sleepiness, confusion or staring spells*. They may also have *trouble sleeping at night* or

may experience *visual hallucinations* (seeing people, objects or shapes that are not actually there).

- **Fronto-temporal dementia.** This type of dementia most often *leads to changes in personality* and *behavior* because of the part of the brain it affects. People with this condition may *embarrass themselves or behave inappropriately*. For instance, a previously cautious person may make offensive comments and neglect responsibilities at home or work. There may also be problems with *language skills* like speaking or understanding.
- **Mixed dementia.** Sometimes more than one type of dementia is present in the brain at the same time, especially in people aged 80 and older. For example, a person may have Alzheimer's disease and vascular dementia. It is not always obvious that a person has mixed dementia since the symptoms of one type of dementia may be most prominent or may overlap with symptoms of another type. Disease progression may be faster than with one kind of dementia.

